

movement. If you cut corners now, it will cost you later. The proper form is to allow your head to simply brush the ground as you maintain correct arm, elbow, and body positions.

It may take time to achieve the strength and balance necessary for this movement. If you need assistance, practice against a wall and remove your feet at different points during the movement with the eventual aim to remove them altogether.

FREESTANDING HANDSTAND PUSHUP – LEVEL 7



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated. As your head comes toward the ground, they will naturally begin to depress and come forward as your elbows move in that direction. Allow this to happen all the way through to the bottom. Your scapulas will then be in a neutral, depressed position. Once your head touches the ground and you start pushing back up, seek to end with your scapulas elevated.

Technique: Begin in a handstand position on raised implements like parallettes, with your body completely straight. Initiate the movement illustrated above by allowing your shoulder angle to close while bending at the elbow. Slowly lower to the ground in a uniform movement. Make sure to keep your body as straight as possible as your head descends toward the ground. Do not arch. Once your head lightly touches the ground, push back up to the starting position. Focus on pushing through your triceps and shoulders, eventually covering your shoulders like earmuffs. End with your body completely straight.

The *freestanding handstand pushup* (which can be abbreviated *Free HSPU*) is a beast of a skill that requires serious dedication. Like wall handstand pushups, this movement should be performed on implements that raise your hands. Parallettes are strongly recommended. They are stable and consistent, assuming that their surface is not slippery. Additionally, the force you can exert through your hands via a tight grip assists with balance during performance of this movement.

Your biggest enemies, as with previous progressions, will be arching your back and flaring your elbows. If the sheer intensity of pressing out of the bottom is too much for you, you can use same approach that was suggested for headstand pushups—slow eccentrics or varying the height of your hands for progressive partial repetitions.

This position and movement should now be extremely familiar; all that is left is to drill it correctly. If you are still having problems with your body positioning, go back to a progression where you can maintain proper positioning throughout the entire movement.

It is absolutely imperative that you learn the body positions correctly. You will not be able to perform any of the more advanced movements correctly without proper body positioning. It is that important.

Rings Handstand Pushups – Page 1, Column 4

RINGS WIDE HANDSTAND PUSHUP – LEVEL 7



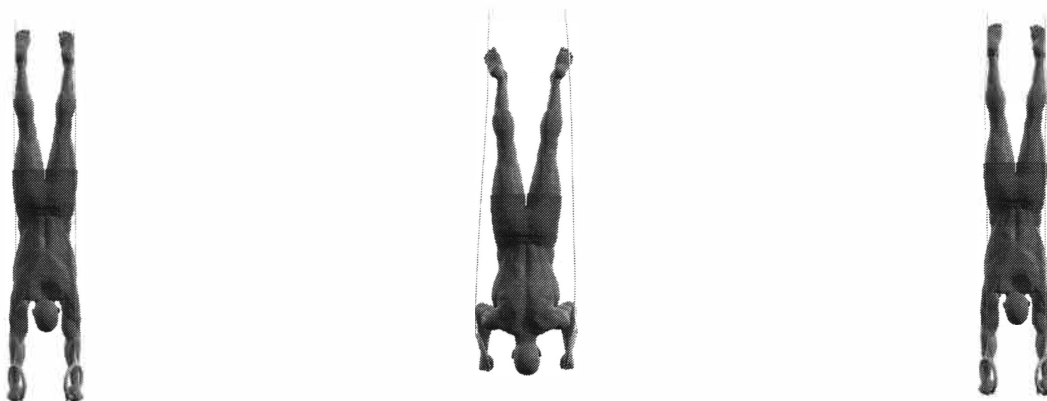
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be fully elevated and very slightly retracted to lock in this position. As you bend your elbows out wide, with your feet on the straps, your scapulas will naturally depress and protract slightly. Allow this to happen to the bottom of the movement. Then, reverse the whole process when pushing up from the bottom.

Technique: Begin in a rings handstand position, with feet on the straps. Keep your feet on the straps for the entire movement. To start the movement, allow your hands to start to move out wider while simultaneously allowing your elbows to bend. This will bring the rings wider and distribute force through your traps, triceps, and shoulders. Once you hit the bottom of the movement, contract your shoulders and push through your hands, bringing them back underneath your shoulders and allowing your feet to slide along the cables. Finish in the rings handstand position with your feet on the straps. In this movement, the rings may rotate from the parallel position to a position where your forearms are on the straps. This is fine to start, but eventually you will want to keep the rings parallel the entire time.

With *rings wide handstand pushups* (which can be abbreviated *R Wide HSPU*) your aim should be to maintain proper straight-body positioning. The primary difference between this and rings handstand development is that you will aim to keep your feet inside the cables and stabilize the movement with just your wrists.

In this instance, allow the elbows to flare out in order to generate additional mechanical advantage while maintaining proper form, especially at the top of the position. Here, you will want to pause in the arms-straight, rings-turned-out, [proper] handstand position. From then on, it is all shoulder and triceps strength, so make sure you have obtained this strength from the previous progressions before attempting this or any other advanced exercise that carries a greater risk of injury.

RINGS STRAP HANDSTAND PUSHUP (WITH ELBOWS IN) – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be fully elevated and very slightly retracted to lock in the position. As you bend your elbows out wide, with your feet on the straps, your scapulas will naturally depress and protract slightly. Allow this to happen to the bottom of the movement. Then, reverse the whole process when pushing up from the bottom.

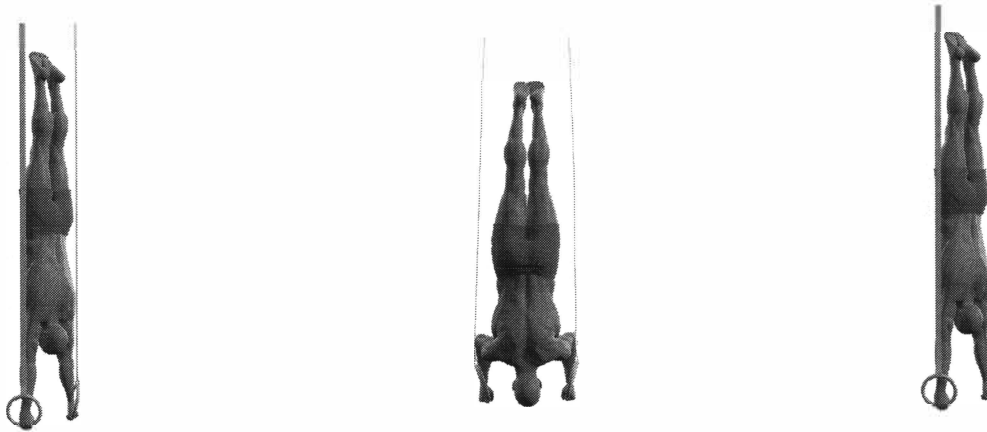
Technique: Begin in a rings handstand position, with feet on the straps. Keep your feet on the straps for the entire movement. To start the movement, allow your hands to start to move out wider while simultaneously allowing your elbows to bend. This will bring the rings wider and distribute force through your traps, triceps, and shoulders. Once you hit the bottom of the movement, contract your shoulders and push through your hands, bringing them back underneath your shoulders and allowing your feet to slide along the cables. Finish in the rings handstand position with your feet on the straps. The rings may rotate from the parallel position to a position where your forearms are on the straps. This is fine to start, but eventually you will want to keep the rings parallel the entire time.

Rings strap handstand pushups (with elbows in) are where your grit is truly tested. This movement can be abbreviated *R Strap HSPU*. To make this more difficult, remove your feet from the cables while in the shoulder stand position at the bottom of the movement. This will require your shoulder stand to be slightly underbalanced, which presents problems with maintaining proper body positioning, especially near the bottom of the movement. Do your best and use the straps as little as necessary to avoid compromising body position. As you ascend, your feet will naturally move back in line with the straps or cables.

This movement is very much like the freestanding handstand pushup on parallel bars (or another raised implement). You have to maintain tension at the bottom of the movement, and you should make it your goal to fire out of the bottom position right away.

Some of the finer technique points are to keep the elbows in and your core tight. Allowing your body to arch to any degree will push your center of gravity toward your back, which may cause you to tip over. If you have a tendency to do this, focus on squeezing your abdominals and glutes during the movement. Keeping your core tight is important for all aspects of handstand pushups.

RINGS FREESTANDING HANDSTAND PUSHUP – LEVEL 9



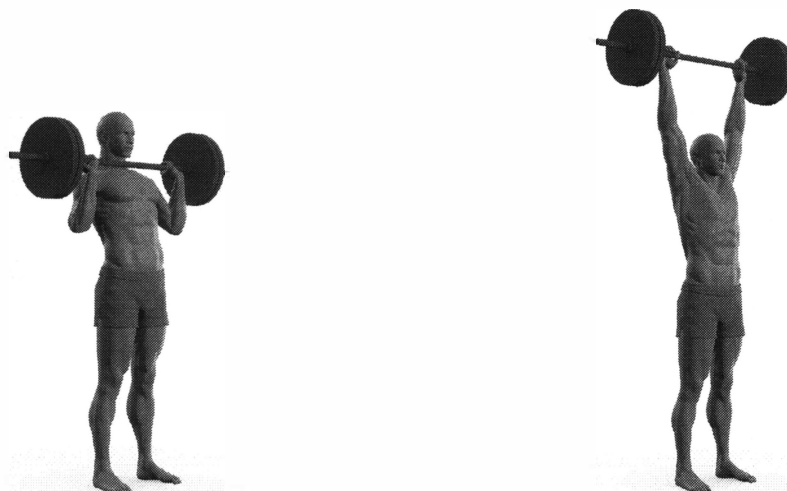
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be fully elevated and very slightly retracted to lock in the position. As you move into the bottom position of the movement keep your elbows in, which will cause your scapulas to depress. Allow this to happen to the bottom of the movement. Then, reverse the whole process when pushing up from the bottom.

Technique: Begin in a rings handstand position, with feet on the straps. Remove your feet from the straps, balancing in the handstand position. To start the movement, allow your hands to move in front of you, toward the front of your shoulders. Once you hit the bottom position—with your hands level at your shoulders—contract your shoulders and push through your hands to move them up and over your head, back into alignment with your body. Finish in the rings handstand position. In this movement, the rings may rotate from the parallel position to a position where your forearms are on the straps. This is fine to start, but eventually you will want to keep the rings parallel the entire time.

The *rings freestanding handstand pushup* (which can be abbreviated *R Free HSPU*) is a milestone of strength for most people, and this is the first rated B skill on the chart. Performing this movement builds on all of the time, sweat, and energy you have put into the previous handstand progressions. Always focus on correct body positioning. Hit the handstand, lower with control, then push explosively out of the bottom and maintain proper body positioning all the way up.

The biggest issue that you will run into is locking out your elbows at the top of the skill. This the most difficult moment during rings freestanding handstand pushups. Obviously, locking out the rings is very difficult, so hopefully you have focused on this aspect of the skill in previous progressions. If you have not done this and you have developed the strength for the rings handstand pushup, you may find that your elbows are bent at the top of the movement. If this is the case, your primary focus must be on locking your arms at the top of the movement. It may actually build more strength in your shoulders than the handstand pushup itself—!

As with most of the handstand variations, you may also have difficulty maintaining a straight or slightly hollowed body during the movement. You may also have to work on the rings parallel (or turned out) position, as the tendency is often to allow them to turn in.

Press / Overhead Press / Military Press – Page 1, Column 5

The *press* appears right after the handstand pushups progressions because it strongly relates to these types of skills. A true freestanding handstand pushup will typically be about 85-95% of a bodyweight press. This is because the weight of your arms is not factored into the weight of a handstand pushup.

Both skills require good core strength and control, but they are a bit different. Obviously, pushing your bodyweight in an inverted position is not exactly like pushing your bodyweight overhead. You will get better at whatever you practice the most. There is some crossover between skills because they both involve pressing weight over your head. But there are no hard-set numbers that correlate from one to the other. This placement on the charts and strength “connection” is just to give you an idea of what you may expect in regard to pressing strength if you were to train both simultaneously. Individual anthropometry will also play a role. Those with longer bodies may have a harder time controlling a freestanding handstand pushup.

The most important factor in how skilled you can become at an exercise is how much you practice it. In this respect, you will be better at what you do more often. But if you need some supplementary work for one skill or the other, these two progressions relate fairly well to each other.

Bent-Arm Press to Handstands – Page 1, Column 6

BENT-ARM, BENT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 5



Scapular Positioning: Initially, your hands will be placed on the ground and your scapulas will be elevated as much as possible, although they will be closer to neutral at the start. Elevate them as you progress through the movement until they are maximally elevated at the end of the handstand position.

Technique: Place your hands on the ground with your arms slightly bent and your legs straight. Slowly shift your weight from your toes to your hands. Once all of the weight is on your hands, lift your feet off the ground. Do not allow your shoulders to drop down further, as this will make the press to handstand more difficult. Bring your hips directly over your shoulders. Straighten out your hips while at the same time pressing through your hands in order to straighten your elbows and shoulder angle. Finish in the freestanding handstand position.

A proficient handstand is a prerequisite to learning the *bent-arm, bent-body press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *BA BB Press*). If you cannot hold a handstand, you will not make it to the ending position of this skill without falling over. That being said, this position is best learned from either a bent-arm straddle or a bent-arm pike position. Tucking is not preferred; though it makes the beginning of the movement slightly easier, once your legs start to extend it is much more unstable than straight legs throughout. In the context of progression and consistency, ignoring straight leg positioning now will mean needing to learn it later when the intensity is inherently higher and risk of injury greater. If you have to switch to a lower progression, bite the bullet now and put in the work required.

Wrist control is crucial in any hand-balancing feat, and this movement is no exception. Begin by firmly planting your hands on the floor with your fingers extended, ready to give feedback and control. Initially, balancing this skill will be difficult, and it is likely that forward rolling out of the skill will occur. Your aim should be to completely avoid this, but be prepared for it to happen if you lose your forward balance.

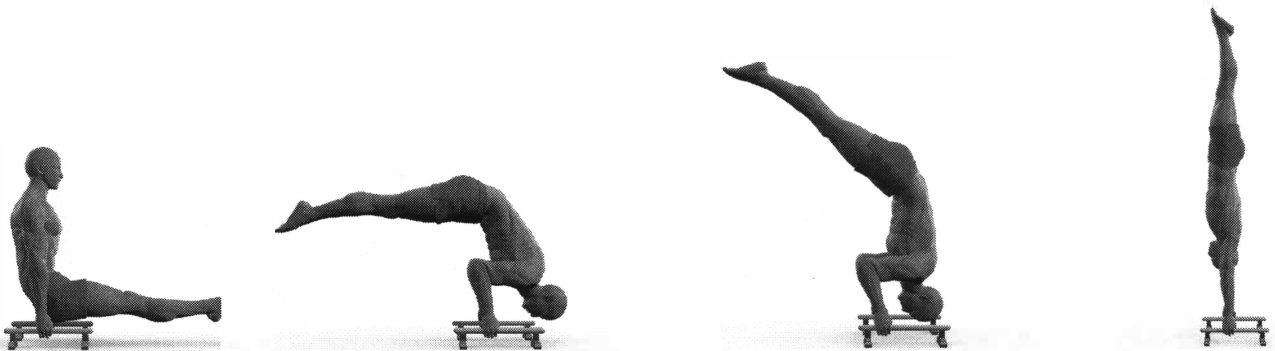
You can begin in either the pike or straddle position. Bend your arms slightly. (Do not bend your arms more than ninety degrees, as this places too much force on your triceps and you may not be strong enough

to push out of the position while your elbows are bent. This applies for this progression and every one from this point forward.) As your arms bend, tension is created from your hands to your shoulders, which provides a stable base for your hips to rise overhead. Once your hips are aligned over your head, begin to straighten the handstand by bringing your legs up. Difficulty level will vary depending on which position you use. Each position has its own difficulties to overcome, so it is difficult to say which is the most difficult.

- *Straddle Position* is usually more difficult at first because of the flexibility requirements and lack of awareness in this position. If you desire to work on these issues, use this position.
- *Pike Position* is cleaner looking and more comfortable, but has its own share of difficulties. Once your legs begin making their way up, they make a longer lever than the straddle. This shifts your center of gravity closer to your feet and further away from your wrists. To compensate, your shoulders have to lean forward more, thus decreasing your shoulder musculature's leverage and effectively increasing the intensity of forces on your shoulders.

Whichever position is chosen, it is just a matter of practice once you have adequate strength to perform this skill. With a solid handstand, this should not take longer than a month or two. Given the basic nature of this skill and its applicability into most other progressions, you might want to practice both variations.

L-SIT BENT-ARM, BENT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: In the L-sit position, your scapulas will be maximally depressed. As you begin to move your head forward and down, your legs back, and your hips up, you will elevate your scapulas as you progress through the movement until they are maximally elevated at the end of the handstand position.

Technique: Place your hands on the ground or parallelles and push through them while performing the L-sit position. Then, begin to lean forward and allow your legs to drop and move backward. Your hips will begin to rise up behind you as you push through your hands. Do not allow your shoulders to drop down further, as this will make the press to handstand more difficult. Bring your hips directly over your shoulders. Straighten out your hips while at the same time pressing through your hands in order to straighten your elbows and shoulder angle. Finish in the freestanding handstand position.

The *L-sit bent-arm, bent-body press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *L-sit BA BB Press*) progression takes the *bent-body press* a step further. Instead of beginning with your body behind your arms, begin with your body in front of your arms and use your upper-body strength to press the skill through your arms, ending in a handstand position.

If you are on the floor, there are two main ways to get your legs through your arms. The tuck position is recommended, though some people like crossing their legs as they bring them through the arms. If you are strong and have long arms, the pike position could work as well. Moving your legs through your arms requires active shoulders and pushing your hands as far out as possible to help build strength for handstand positions. Once your legs get through, the skill is similar to the previous progression. Remember to focus on pushing your hips above your head without bending your arms more than ninety degrees.

It is easier if you use parallelles as you raise your body off the ground. This is not recommended; however, if you are just beginning to learn this skill and do not have the ability to get your legs through, this is an okay method to use. Pretend that there is an imaginary plane at the parallelles' height and try not to break that plane as you perform the skill. Take the skill to the floor as you progress.

CHEST ROLL, STRAIGHT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 7



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas protracted and depressed. Elevate them through the movement. Keeping them protracted through the movement is acceptable, but they will eventually end up in elevation with slight retraction as you move into the handstand.

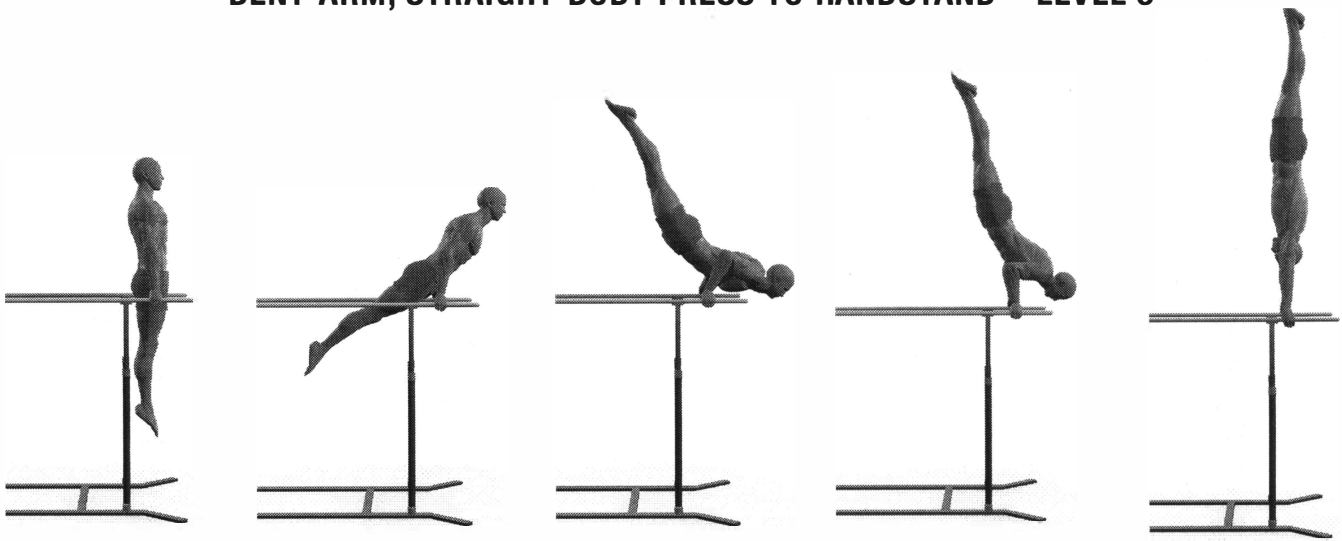
Technique: Begin in a seal position, with your hands on the ground and body arched. Bend your arms and allow the front of your body to gain a bit of momentum as you roll on the ground. Arch your back and allow your feet to rise up behind you. As more weight is shifted onto your hands, your hips will start to rise up behind you. As your head reaches the ground, push strongly through your hands. Do not allow your shoulders to drop down further, as this will make the press to handstand more difficult. Bring your hips directly over your shoulders. Straighten out your hips while at the same time pressing through your hands in order to straighten your elbows and shoulder angle. Finish in the freestanding handstand position.

As you begin to work the *chest roll, straight-body press to handstand* skill (which can be abbreviated *CR SB Press*), you may notice that it is not uncommon for your body to arch significantly. As you get stronger, eliminate this arch and complete the skill with a straight-body position that relies on shoulder and arm strength. Doing this will help prepare you for the next progression.

This skill requires a solid amount of back flexibility, so it can be difficult for those who are less flexible. Even though this skill may not be your cup of tea, developing the bridge is an important part of training. However, it is possible to avoid this skill altogether and build up strength through other movements until you can progress to the next press progression.

Alternatively, you can think about this movement in two parts. First, you want to be able to press into a headstand position. Second, you want to be able to press from said headstand position into a handstand. When you think about it in this manner, this exercise becomes much less daunting. You can work on both components individually and eventually pair them if you are having trouble doing both in one continuous movement.

BENT-ARM, STRAIGHT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas depressed. They will start to protract through the movement and become elevated as you move toward the handstand. You will end with your scapulas elevated and slightly retracted.

Technique: Begin in a support position on parallel bars or parallettes. Bend your arms and lean forward, controlling the descent of your shoulders as your feet rise behind you. As your head reaches the height of your hands, push strongly through your hands. Do not allow your shoulders to drop down further, as this will make the press to handstand more difficult. Bring your hips directly over your shoulders. Straighten out your hips while at the same time pressing through your hands in order to straighten your elbows and shoulder angle. Finish in the freestanding handstand position.

A *bent-arm straight-body press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *BA SB Press*) is also referred to as a *hollowback press handstand*. The difficulty level of this movement can vary significantly depending on how much momentum is used. If your overarching goal is increasing your level of strength, you should strive to reduce the amount of momentum necessary to hit the final handstand.

This skill is most easily performed on parallettes or an actual set of parallel bars. It can be performed on the floor, but it is significantly harder because the floor blocks any movement of the legs that would be lower than the ground. If you do not have access to parallel bars, use parallettes and begin from the kneeling position. As you lean forward, straighten your legs as soon as possible to execute this skill as close to the parallel bars as you can. Alternatively, you start in an L-sit position: Allow your legs to drop so that your body is straight. As your legs pass through the bottom of the movement, lean forward and bend your arms simultaneously.

The key to this skill is not to bend over or lean too fast; you want to make a controlled pendulum with your body. You will move through three landmarks near the following positions: elbow lever, shoulder stand, and freestanding handstand pushup from the bottom of the shoulder stand position.

While the movements are similar, this skill requires more strength than a freestanding handstand pushup. This is why it is one level higher in difficulty, making it the logical next step after you have mastered freestanding handstand pushups.

Note that the illustrations show this skill performed with an arch. This is fine when you are learning; however, as you improve, perform it with a hollow position. This will increase strength in your shoulder girdle more effectively.

HANDSTAND TO ELBOW LEVER TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 9



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be elevated at the top of the handstand position. As you begin to lower, they will protract and depress. This will continue to the elbow lever position. From there, your scapulas will move in the opposite direction as you press back to the handstand position.

Technique: Begin in a handstand position. Bend your elbows and shoulders, allowing your chest and head to come forward and your feet to drop backward. Lower in a slow and controlled manner to the elbow lever position. From this position, lean forward slightly to allow your feet to rise. Then, push through your hands with your shoulders and elbows to move back to the handstand position.

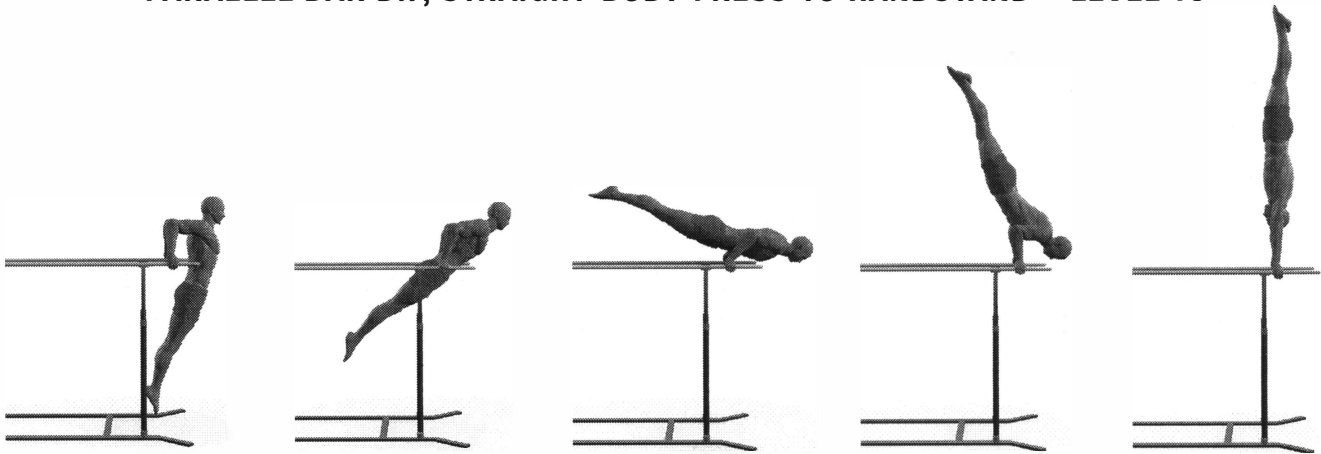
Handstand to elbow lever to handstand (which can be abbreviated *HS, EL, HS*) is a strength move that is known as a *90-degree pushup*, and it is all about impressive pressing strength in multiple planes. Perform this skill with a straight body; a good handstand is a prerequisite. You should also be proficient in freestanding handstand pushups and the bent-arm, straight-body press.

Think of your hands as the fulcrum on which your body balances. Allow your elbows to come tight to your sides in order to help balance the body. The angle of your elbows must then be opened and closed to balance the skill. If you attempt to balance the skill with just your shoulder or hands it will not work. The angle of your elbows will help control the skill and keep it in a static position. Your elbow can then be opened or closed to help initiate the ascent or descent of the skill, respectively.

The lack of momentum in this movement is what makes it so difficult. With previous skills, you could get some momentum rolling from the support or L-sit position in the initial lean. However, in this skill, you must control your body as you come down from a handstand so that you stop statically in an elbow lever position. Then, starting in this static elbow lever position, you must create your own movement from strength and control it all the way back up to a handstand.

Do not try to make this skill easy by bending your legs and arching your back. Keep your body straight. Develop a sense of balance for getting in and out of the elbow lever position. If you are having difficulty, review the section on elbow lever statics for advice on how to balance this intermediate position.

PARALLEL BAR DIP, STRAIGHT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Begin in a relaxed position at the bottom of a dip with your scapulas elevated and retracted. Activate your shoulders and depress and protract your scapulas. As you move through the various positions, your scapulas will stay protracted and begin to elevate. Continue the elevation until you reach the handstand position; they will naturally move out of protraction.

Technique: Begin in a support position and lower into a dip. (Alternatively, you can start in a dip.) At the bottom of the dip, activate your shoulders and lean forward. As you do this, push through your hands. Your body will begin to rotate, causing your feet to rise. Keep your body straight and continue to lean forward so your hips and feet will rise further to a shoulder stand position. From there, press out into a handstand.

The *parallel bar dip, straight-body press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *PB Dip SB to HS*) is a feat of strength that tests the body through the full range of pushing movements. This move requires a set of parallel bars. From the bottom of the dip position, keep your body straight (do not arch your back!) and lean forward to press into a handstand.

This movement can be performed with parallettes if you start from the third frame in this sequence. You will not get the full range of motion to build strength, but starting from a static position in the third frame is sufficiently difficult to challenge your strength.

Initiate the movement by leaning your body forward while straightening your arms so that your shoulders “slide” along the rails. This will help place your hands closer to your hips, necessary to get the rest of your body leaning forward to push out of the deep dip position into the ascent.

As your body approaches being parallel to the bars, you will be in a deep semi-elbow lever position. Do not stop in this position, as it is much more difficult than a regular elbow lever. You want to keep leaning forward and open your elbow angle so that your feet keep rising until you come close to hitting a shoulder stand on the parallel bars. From there, all that is left is the bottom portion of the freestanding handstand pushup movement.

The first phase—the dip to approximately a shoulder stand—is the hardest. At this level, handstand push-ups are typically comfortable for trainees and they are less of a problem. However, it should be noted that this will be slightly more difficult because you are taxing yourself in the first phase, before the handstand pushup. From there, the next step is to develop the necessary strength and learn how to manipulate your elbow angle to allow you to change the angle of your body so that it is set up for a press.

Rings Bent-Arm Press to Handstands – Page 1, Column 7

In order to keep the progression charts as simple as possible, *rings bent-arm press* movements have not been given their own category, instead they come after *chair handstands*.

The upper level chair handstand—the illusion—requires a lot of the stability and strength needed when learning rings bent-arm press handstand movements. It makes a good segue into rings handstands.

While other work on rings, such as rings handstand pushups, may ultimately be more useful, it is best to learn some movements concurrently. It is beneficial to learn rings handstands, rings handstand pushups, and straight-arm/bent-arm press handstands on PB/FX before rings bent-arm press movements.

CHAIR HANDSTAND – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: As you begin this movement, the scapula on your *down arm* will be protracted and elevated, while the scapula on your *up arm* will be in a neutral position. Through the movement, the scapula on your down arm will become elevated to a final handstand positioning, while the scapula on your up arm will remain in place.

Technique: First, squat on a chair. Find the correct hand placements—your *down arm* should be on the front corner of the seat of the chair and your other arm (the *up arm*) should be on the backrest of the chair. To initiate the movement, raise your butt in the air and begin leaning forward. The chair handstand is a two-step process. The first part involves moving your hips directly overhead of your shoulders. The second part involves slowly extending your legs overhead while keeping your shoulders, core, and hips stable. This will prevent you from falling forward or backward.

Your *down arm* should be kept straight when the press begins. (This is why it is useful to already have a straight-arm press.) If your arm bends more than about twenty to thirty degrees, your body will rotate and you will fail the press. Your *up arm* can support some weight, but since it is bent you will not have much leverage or strength to support any significant weight on that arm. Continue to lean forward and put weight on your down arm: think about pushing upward in a straight line to your head. This will help counteract force as you lean forward and lift your hips up.

Your legs can be in either a tuck or straddle position when you attempt this press. Many people prefer the tuck position, but straddle can be easier if you have been practicing straddle presses. Be aware that your feet will hit the backrest of the chair if you use straddle.

Now that you have gotten your hips above your head, slowly extend your legs overhead. If you do this too quickly, you are likely to arch your back and lose your balance. If you do not yet know how to pirouette out of a handstand, you are strongly advised to learn this against a wall first. You absolutely do not want to fall straight over and land on your back on the ground!

After you have reached the handstand position, keep your body tight. Roughly 75% of your weight will shift to the arm that is planted against the ground, so any core or leg movement can easily de-stabilize your press. Apply force to keep yourself planted, and place your up arm on the backrest for control when coming down. Your body may twist when you are first learning this, but the twist will go away once you get the hang of the skill.

Before attempting a chair handstand, you should have the ability to hold a thirty-second handstand and perform a bent-arm press handstand or a near-straight-arm straddle press handstand. Executing this skill requires being able to press to a handstand and hold a handstand. Performing handstand pushups may help, but they are not a prerequisite.

The chair handstand is actually not a very difficult skill, even though it looks impressive. Keep in mind the differences between chair handstands and regular handstands: in order to correctly execute a chair handstand, the placement of your down arm must be biased toward the front of the chair, while your up arm is placed higher on the back of the chair, creating a staggered hand position for the execution of the handstand. The horizontal distance between your hands should be roughly shoulder width, while the vertical distance between your hands can vary (though the length of the space from elbow to shoulder is typically good). Your down arm will bear most of the weight of the handstand (typically 70-80%), while your up arm will stabilize it. Optimally, your up arm will be bent at 90-degree angle at both your shoulder and your elbow, which will help bias the weight toward your down arm.

Be sure that the elbow of your planted arm does not flare out; keep it lined up with your body as you press up and while you are in the handstand position itself. If your body keeps twisting, the cause may be a flared elbow.

There is a high potential that you may fall out of the chair press when you are learning this movement, so learning these against a wall is advised. When you take the movement away from the wall, make sure there is a soft surface in front of you in the event that you fall forward. Make sure you practice pirouetting out of a handstand.

Coming down out of the chair press is exactly like going up. First, bring your legs down slowly until you are in a straddle or tuck position with your hips up. Next, use your arms to slowly bend and support your weight. You can then bring your hips down from overhead. Ideally, you will be able to execute this without wobbling, slamming your feet onto the chair or falling over. Keep practicing!

After you have achieved a chair handstand, work toward holding it for longer time periods in order to improve your stability, just as you would a regular handstand. You will eventually be able to perform it from a starting position of being seated sideways on a chair, much like the L-sit press handstand variation. The toughest part of this skill is getting your lower body overhead from the position of being seated on the chair.

Do not forget to practice both sides. You will often see inequality in straight-arm and bent-arm strength while working this movement. Work your weaker arm first.

ILLUSION CHAIR HANDSTAND – LEVEL 7



Scapular Positioning: Same as the chair handstand.

Technique: Same as the chair handstand, except there is more instability in your *up arm* because it is resting on the backrest of a different chair.

The illusion chair handstand uses two chairs. You will not place your hand on the first chair, as the back legs of the second chair will be where you would place your planted arm. Instead, place your down arm hand on the back of the chair, and your up arm on the back of the other chair. While this press is basically the same as the previous chair press movement, it is more difficult for two distinct reasons:

- Your up arm must stabilize the rest of the body by controlling any twisting and lateral motion, which means even less support can be put on that arm.
- Your down arm will have more weight placed on it, as you cannot place as much weight on the other arm for control.

Aside from the increased weight distribution, you have stabilized the chair with your up arm. Your elbow must not be allowed to flare out. If you are having issues keeping your elbow in, you may need to go back to working press movements on the floor or parallettes.

As you begin the press to a handstand, your down arm should remain straight. If your arm bends more than twenty degrees, your body will rotate and the movement will fail. While your up arm can support some weight, you do not have much leverage because it is bent. Keep your elbow from flaring out and isometrically squeeze the shoulder of your up arm in order to support some weight and prevent it from wobbling. Put most of your weight on your down arm, and think about pushing through it so that your hand is in a direct straight line with your head. Take care not to lean too far forward as it is easy to lose balance. This will allow you to lift your hips up and over your head.

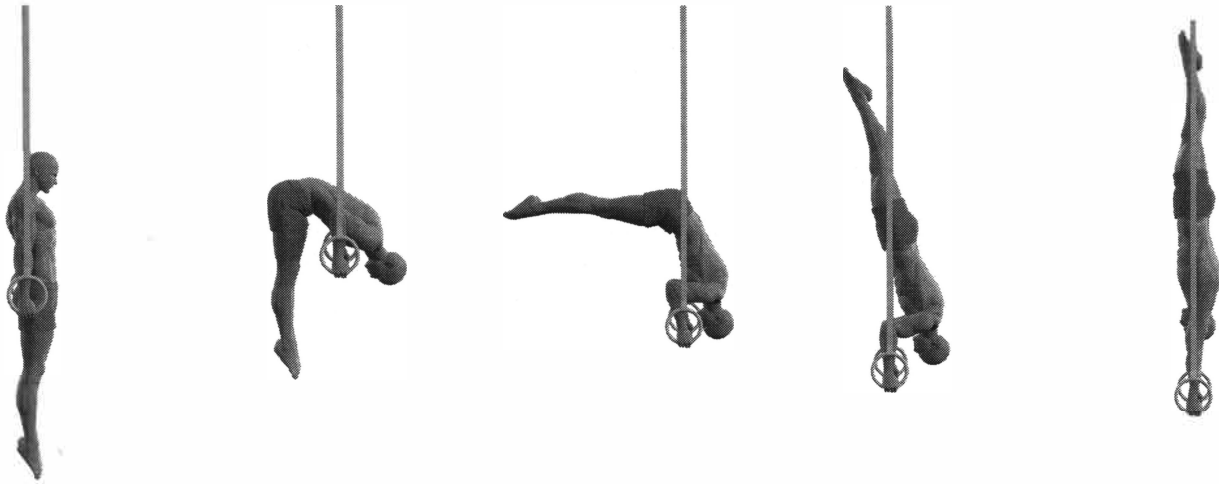
Your legs can be in either a tuck or straddle position when attempting this press; it is a matter of personal preference. Like with the chair handstand, most people prefer the tuck position, as your feet may hit the back of the chair if you use the straddle position.

Once your hips are above your head, slowly extend your legs overhead. If you do this too quickly, you are likely to arch your back and lose your balance. After you have reached the handstand position, keep your body tight. Roughly 75% of your weight will shift to the arm that is planted against the ground, so any core or leg movement is likely to de-stabilize your press. Apply force to keep yourself planted, and place your up arm on the backrest for control when coming down. Your body may twist when you are first learning this, but this will go away once you get the hang of it.

There is an intermediate position that can be utilized to practice this skill. Using three chairs, start with the top chair resting on two bottom chairs. After you perform the chair press handstand, take control of the chair and pull it up so that it is not resting on the third chair. If there is another person around, they can pull out the third chair as well. This is where the “illusion” comes in—because the third chair is useless.

As always, this skill can be practiced against the wall or next to a soft surface in case you fall over. Once it is obtained, there are some things you can do to increase the challenge, such as straightening your supporting arm. You can also go higher if you have access to stackable chairs.

RINGS BENT-ARM, BENT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: Begin in the support position, with your scapulas depressed. As you move into this skill, your scapulas will begin to elevate and protract. As you move closer to the handstand position they will protract less and elevate more. As you reach the handstand position they will be fully elevated and slightly retracted.

Technique: This skill should be approached much like the *rings shoulder stand* and other bent-arm, bent-body presses. From a support or L-sit position, bend your arms and rotate your torso forward to get your hips above your head. From there, you can either straddle or pike to get your hips all the way over your head. Finally, push through your arms and simultaneously straighten your hips to move into a rings handstand position.

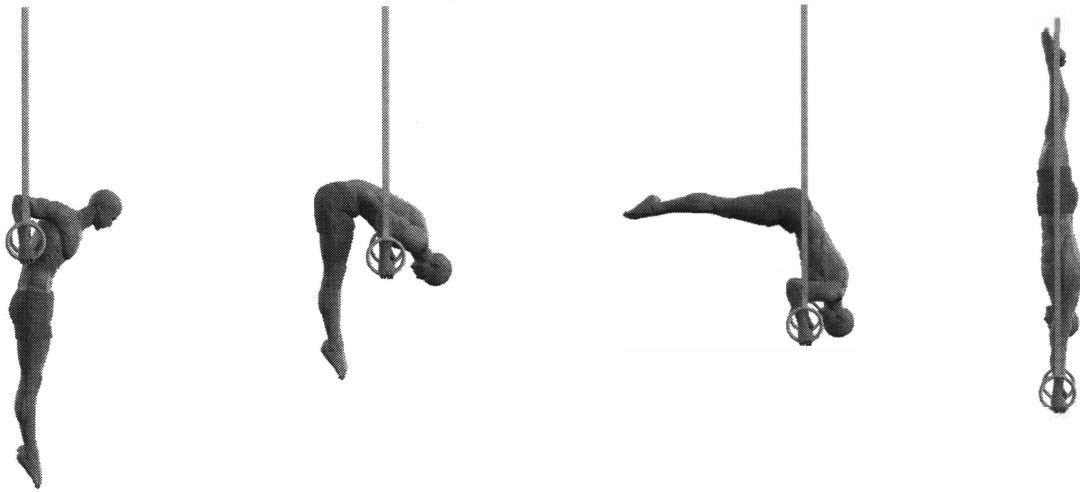
Achieving the support position variation of the *rings bent-arm, bent-body press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *RBA BB Press*) will be significantly harder, as you have no momentum from a swing. Remember to keep your arms bent as much as is necessary to get your hips overhead. Aside from this, bend your arms as little as possible because it is very difficult to press out of the bottom of the movement with a closed elbow angle. As your hips rise in the back, put as much force as necessary into the rings to ensure that your elbow positioning does not drop below a 90-degree angle.

At first, you will likely have to use the straps for balance. Most beginners do not have the stability required to complete the full range of motion with no assistance. Your goal, however, should always be to use as little assistance as possible, and to wean yourself away from using assistance as you make progress with the movement. Fight to get as high as you can without using the straps. If you are unable to gain control, you can *then* use the straps for assistance.

Once you have reached the top of the handstand, the same points discussed in the rings strap handstand section apply:

- Straight-body positioning is a necessity. Focus on squeezing your glutes and core; arching your body will cause you to lose your balance and fall.
- Lock your elbows straight and shrug your shoulders.
- Wrap your legs around the cables as little as possible. Move them to the inside as you progress, and eventually off of the cables entirely.
- Turn the rings out, to the point where they are at least parallel.

RINGS DIP TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 9



Scapular Positioning: Begin in a dip position, with your scapulas elevated. To begin the movement, depress your scapulas. As you move into this skill, your scapulas will begin to elevate and protract. As you move closer to the handstand position they will protract less and elevate more. As you reach the handstand position they will be fully elevated and slightly retracted.

Technique: This skill should be approached much like the *rings shoulder stand* and other bent-arm, bent-body presses. From the dip position, lean forward and rotate your torso to get your hips all the way over your head. Finally, push through your arms and simultaneously straighten your hips to move into a rings handstand position.

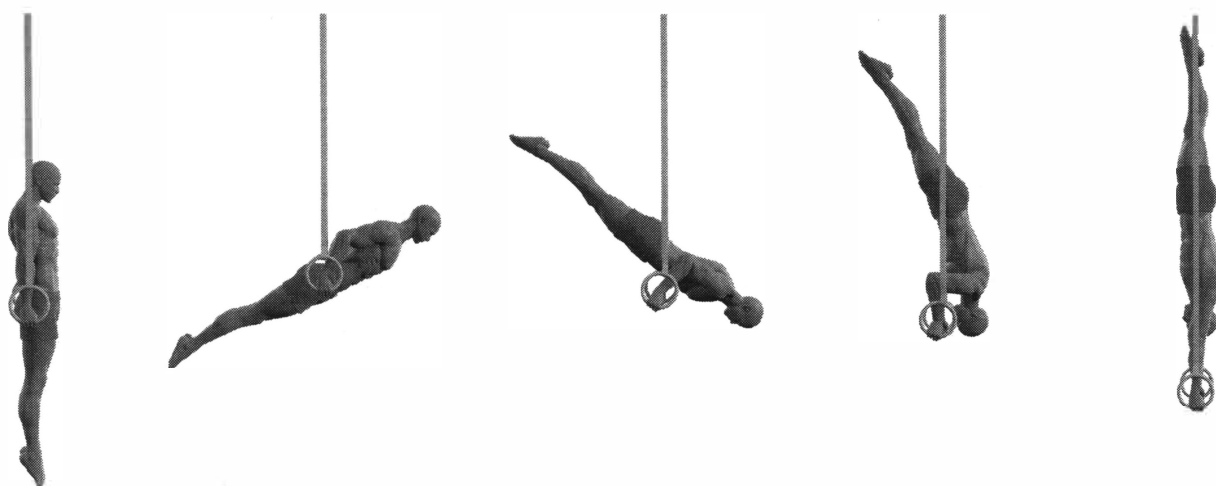
Like on the parallettes, the main difference with the *rings dip to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *R Dip to HS*) is that you are devoid of any momentum that can be generated from the L-sit or lean forward. All of the strength from the dip must be applied to help get your hips overhead.

It is cheating to make this movement much easier by using a tuck position or bending your legs during the dip phase. Your focus is to get stronger. Therefore, use the straddle or pike position and avoid the tuck position. It is acceptable to use the tuck position as an intermediate progression if needed, but once you have the necessary strength you should move on to either the straddle or pike position.

The key here is the lean forward from the bottom portion of the dip. This opens your elbows and allows your torso to rotate forward. As discussed, rotating your torso will help you get your hips overhead. Adding intensity to the dip is conducive to strength gains as well.

This is a good intermediate skill for muscle-up directly into press handstand, which looks very impressive. If you are interested in combining skills or working on routines, this is a good combination to use with the muscle-up or any other type of dip variation.

RINGS BENT-ARM, STRAIGHT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Begin in the support position, with your scapulas depressed. As you move into this skill, your scapulas will elevate and protract. As you move closer to the handstand position they will protract less and elevate more. As you reach the handstand position they will be fully elevated and slightly retracted.

Technique: From the support position, lean forward and bend your arms to exert pressure into your hands and cause your feet to rise. Keep your body straight as you do this. As your head passes below the rings, bring the rings in to hit the shoulder stand position. From there, push your hands overhead to reach the handstand position.

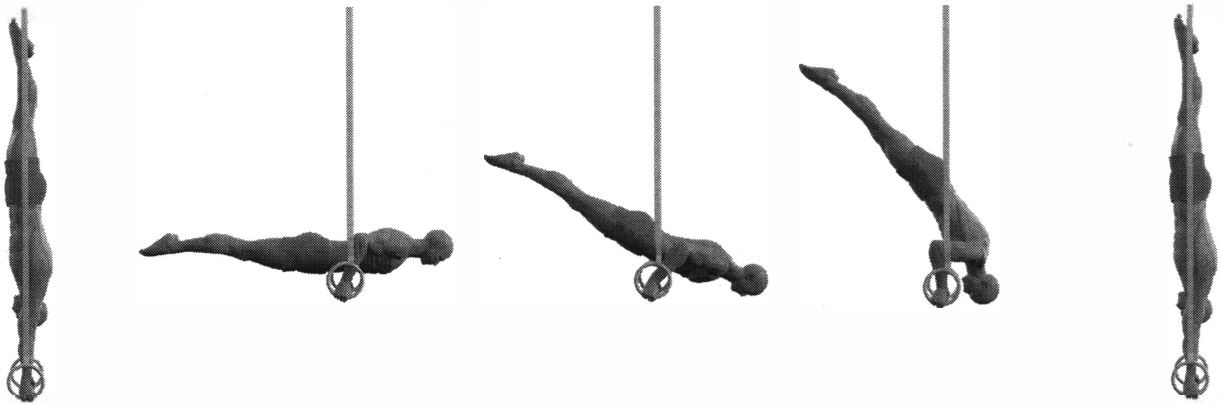
The key for the *rings bent-arm, straight-body press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *R BA SB Press* and is also known as the *hollowback press*) is to turn your palms forward into the rings-turned-out position—much like the elbow lever, bent-arm press progression. This allows you to have more control over the skill. Try to keep the rings turned out as much as possible during the entire skill, even the handstand. This will be difficult.

If your elbow angle is not closed fast enough, you will rotate too far and forward roll or crash out of the skill. Remember to practice bailing if you are not yet comfortable with this. If you bend your arms too soon you will get stuck, and your body will not rotate. A fine line of strength and control is essential to achieve this skill. It will take a lot of practice to get it right.

If you look on the progressions charts you will find that this skill is one level above rings freestanding handstand pushups. Work that skill as well if you have not already done so. The charts were designed so that lateral skills of all levels are approximately on the same difficulty plane, making this somewhat of a continuation of the freestanding handstand pushups line.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS HANDSTAND TO ELBOW LEVER TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 11



Scapular Positioning: Begin in a handstand position with your scapulas fully elevated and slightly retracted. As you move into the skill, your scapulas will begin to depress and protract as you move toward the elbow lever position. Once you hit this position, your scapulas will be fully depressed and protracted. As you make your way toward the handstand position, they will begin to elevate again. You will end with your scapulas fully elevated and slightly retracted.

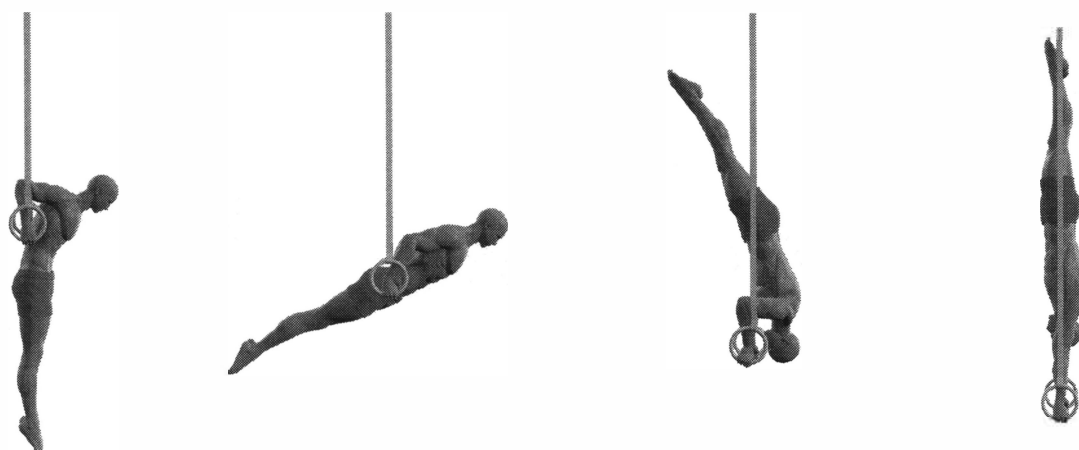
Technique: From a handstand position, lean forward and bend your arms and shoulders. Maintain straight-body positioning. Slowly lower your elbows into your waist area, maintaining pressure through your hands. Once you hit the elbow lever position, lean forward to bring your feet and hips back up. Close the elbow angle to reach a shoulder stand position, then press out of the shoulder stand into a handstand position.

The *rings handstand to elbow lever to handstand* skill (which can be abbreviated *R HS, EL, HS*) is exactly the same as the one you would execute on the floor, parallettes, or parallel bar. The key to successfully achieving this skill is maintaining a straight-body position. Focus on controlling the handstand down by leaning forward and using your wrists to control the rings, and your shoulders and elbow angle to control your body angle.

The elbow lever portion on the rings is much harder than on the floor because it is difficult to pull the elbows in if the rings are regulation width, and the hands must be stabilized while the elbows pull in as well. Try to lock your elbows hard against your sides, but do not forget that the position is controlled with the opening and closing of the elbow angle and the wrists. Once this is working smoothly, the rest is simply ascending and descending a handstand pushup.

The rings must be turned out when coming down from the handstand to the elbow lever. This will probably happen automatically. If your head arches out, it may encourage the arching of the back during the movement. Try to avoid this. To develop the greatest level of strength, keep the nice hollow body position the entire time. Stabilizing and moving in and out of the elbow lever position to and from handstand makes this skill difficult. It requires much more control over the rotation of the skill than the previous progression.

RINGS DIP, STRAIGHT-BODY PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 12



Scapular Positioning: Begin in a dip position, with your scapulas elevated. Depress them as you start the movement. As you lean forward into the movement, your scapulas will elevate and protract. As you move closer to the handstand position they will protract less and elevate more. As you reach the handstand position they will be fully elevated and slightly retracted.

Technique: From a dip position, lean forward and bend your arms to exert pressure into your hands and cause your feet to rise. Keep your body straight. As your head passes below the rings, bring the rings in to hit the shoulder stand position. From there, push your hands overhead to reach the handstand position.

The *rings dip, straight-body press to handstand* skill (which can be abbreviated *R Dip SB to HS*) is exactly the same as the previous variation (dip, straight-body press to handstand) except it is performed on the rings. The rings must be turned out in the ascent phase for control purposes.

As your body approaches being parallel with the bars, you will be in a deep semi-elbow lever position. This is a hybrid between a planche pushup and a maltese pushup. At this point, you want to continue leaning forward and opening your elbow angle so that your feet continue to rise, until you hit close to a shoulder stand on the rings. From there, move into the bottom portion of a freestanding handstand pushup. This is the most difficult part of the skill, so be sure to maintain good form.

Once you learn the basics of this skill, focus on developing strength and manipulating your elbow angle so that you can bring your body overhead. Once you achieve this you can add a weight vest to make the skill more difficult and gain even more strength.

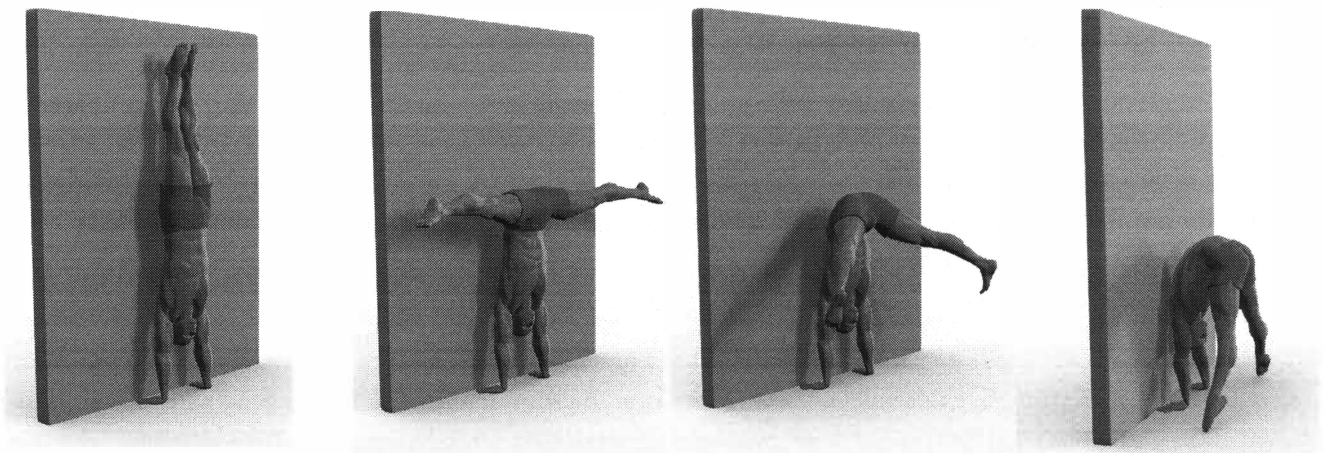
Straight-Arm Press to Handstands – Page 1, Column 8

The *straight-arm press to handstand* variations are extremely underutilized in non-gymnastics scenarios. Everyone wants to obtain cool skills like *handstand pushups* and static holds like the *planche*, but very few have the dedication to achieve the strength and flexibility for the straight-arm press to handstand skill-set progression.

It is unfortunate, since the strength and control you can gain from these skills will help significantly in the development of other skills like the *planche*.

If you have any aspirations for *planche* skills (and even most of the bent-arm pressing skills), it is strongly advised that you develop this set of progressions for pressing first. Learning to control your body from just your shoulders is very important, and you will see the benefits from learning this set of progressions not just in your pressing skills, but also in most of the pulling skills that require straight-arm stabilization, such as back levers, front levers, and even the iron cross.

WALL STRADDLE PRESS TO HANDSTAND ECCENTRICS – LEVEL 5



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be elevated when you are in a handstand position. They will stay elevated for the entirety of this movement. All of the motion will come from your hips.

Technique: Begin in a handstand position with your back against the wall and hands a few inches further from the wall than usual. Next, straddle your legs as wide as possible. Slowly bend at your hips while keeping your back and butt against the wall. Bring your feet closer to the ground and keep your butt against the wall as long as possible. If you are not fully compressed, your butt and back will likely come off the wall before your feet reach the ground. This is fine when you are starting out, but you will need to correct it to progress in the skill.

This is the first progression in the series of progressions that will significantly improve your active flexibility and shoulder strength. *Wall straddle press to handstand eccentrics* (which can be abbreviated *Wall Str. Press Ecce.*) can be performed either on the floor or with parallettes placed against a wall. To make this skill easier, move your hands further away from the wall, at a more oblique angle. To make this skill more challenging (and thus gain greater strength), move your hands closer to the wall.

This skill is best thought of as a two-step process. (The actual press handstand will be a three-step process.) Here are the two steps for this movement:

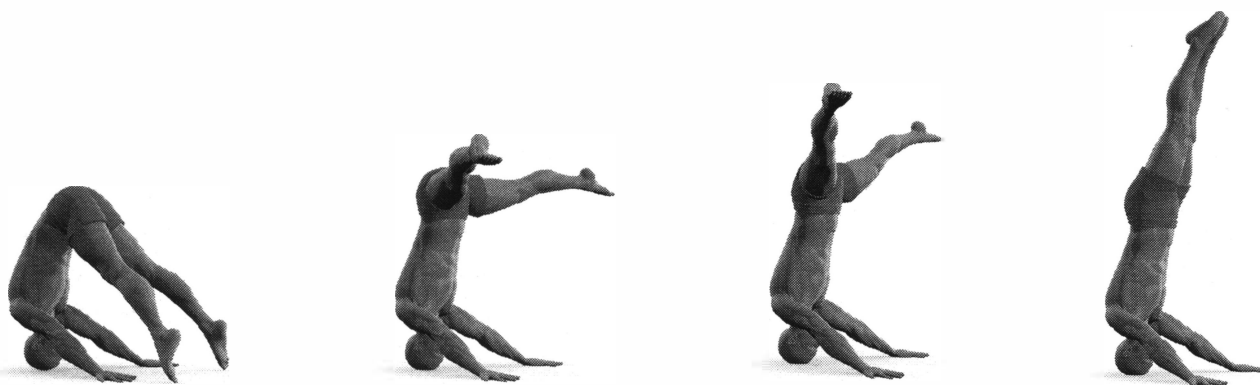
- Begin with your back against the wall in a handstand position. Maintain core tension and do not arch your body. From there, to initiate the movement, straddle your legs as far as possible.
- Slowly rotate your hips so that your feet begin dropping toward the ground and your groin moves toward your abdominal region. Continue slowly until your feet touch the ground. Keep your back straight against the wall the entire time; otherwise, you will likely fall out of the movement.

You need to practice these two transitions thoroughly before progressing to the next skill. While this skill may seem relatively easy, it requires a high level of concentration, strength and control. Most trainees will experience cramping and break into a heavy sweat after performing just a couple of repetitions. Though this is only a Level 5 skill, it is probably the most difficult Level 5 skill on the progression charts. It is also one of the most critical for developing straight-arm strength.

It requires a lot of core control and shoulder strength to keep your back against the wall during this movement. The difficulty of this skill lies in having enough active flexibility in your legs to perform the straddle and in the groin to close your hips, and being able to control the movement while simultaneously being able to drive your shoulders hard into the wall to keep your back in position. Here are two ways you can improve the quality of this skill once you have learned the basic movements:

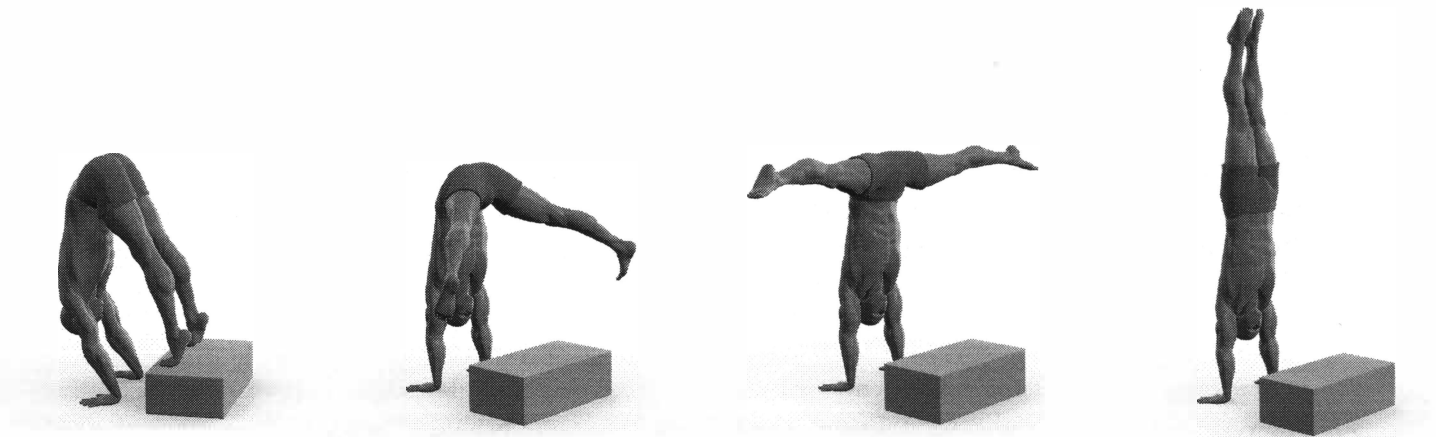
- Once your legs reach your current flexibility limit (as far down as they can go), bring them back up, focusing on the reverse of what you just did. Rotate your hips and legs up to hit a solid core position before bringing them together. All of this should be done without arching your back.
- Use parallettes to allow your legs to drop lower than the floor (as long as we are flexible enough). From there, they can be brought back up. The lower you are able to drop your legs and control them before coming back up, the more challenging this skill becomes.

Remember, even a “small” five to ten degree bend in your elbows will make the movement about ten to thirty percent easier—and strength gains will be fewer. Therefore, you should resist the urge to bend your elbows. This is why most gymnastics coaches do not teach bent-arm pressing until straight-arm pressing is learned.



Pictured above is one of the ways you can begin to practice the hip movement away from the wall, without relying on it. Since this is a headstand position, take precautions to ensure neck safety. If you have any form of neck injury or suspect you may have issues putting pressure on your head, do not attempt this position. If you choose to use this method, you do so at your own risk.

ELEVATED STRADDLE STAND, STRADDLE PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas begin elevated. They will stay elevated for the entirety of this movement. All of the motion will come from your hips.

Technique: Grab a block, stool, gymnastics mat, or other slightly raised implement. The higher the object, the easier the movement will be. Begin with your hands on the ground and lean forward, keeping your shoulder angle open. As your weight shifts to your hands, lift your hips over your head. Once you begin to feel that your feet are barely supporting your weight, slowly rotate your hips to a straddle handstand position. Bring your legs together and you will reach a handstand position.

Switching from wall eccentrics to this full movement called the *elevated straddle stand, straddle press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *Ele Str Std Str Press*) represents the point where you should be able to control a press handstand movement beginning from the ground. If you have difficulty performing this skill, you can use another object with the wall until you are familiar with the concentric portion of the movement.

While this skill is categorized on the same level as the *bent-arm, bent-body press to handstand*, it is inherently more difficult. Few people have much experience with straight-arm skill or strength work, and the increase in intensity brings a substantial increase in muscle adaptation with it. You can adjust the difficulty level by changing the height of the implements, so select a height for the block that suits your experience/skill level. Most people start with a block that is twelve to seventeen inches tall. If you have a gymnastics mat that folds out (like a panel mat), you can systematically decrease the height as you progress.

The main idea is to open your shoulders as far as you can without opening your hips at all. This will help you avoid the common tendency of trying to lift your feet before your hips get all the way up, which would result in a planche press—an exponentially harder skill that you may not be ready for.

You will immediately be able to gauge the difficulty of this new position. Once your feet are in the air, the burden of work falls primarily on your shoulders. It will feel like there is a heavy weight on your shoulders that makes you want to fall forward on your face. Therefore, you must continually and aggressively push your arms over your head, in order to generate enough force at your shoulders to keep your body from tipping over. Your palms and fingers should feel like they are digging hard into the ground.

Most people will get “stuck” on this progression for some time. Because your shoulders end up in a very disadvantaged angle, they must be strong in order to hold this position. You will also need significant active

flexibility in your legs and groin to give your shoulders as much mechanical advantage as possible by drawing the center of gravity closer to your body. Even with many years of training under your belt, nailing this move may seem impossible. Stick with it, as it will build a foundation to achieve a high level of pressing strength. If truly needed, get someone to help spot the skill from behind at your hips. They can brace your shoulders with their knees and move your hips to get your legs up while forcing you to maintain proper body positioning.

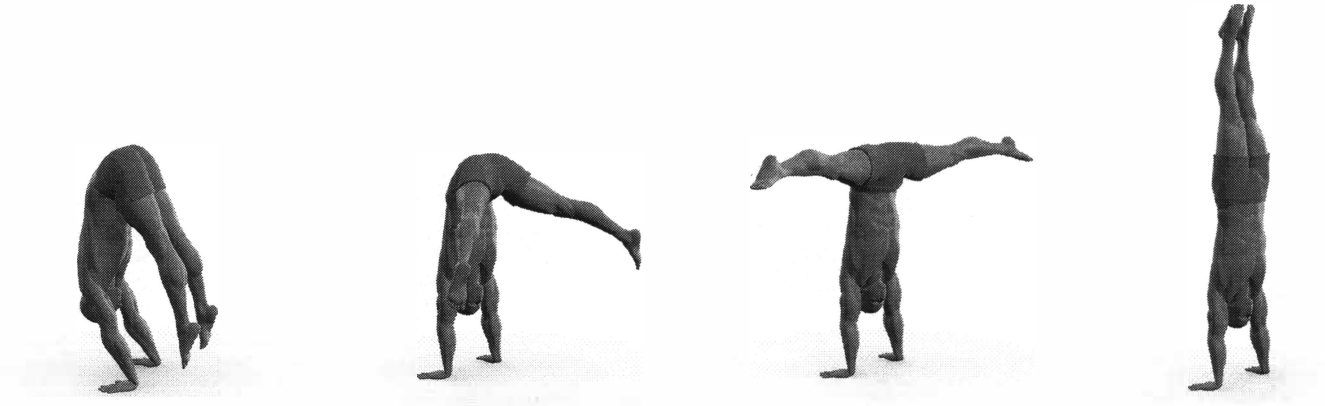
Continue to lower the height of the implement (and, consequentially, your feet) as your strength and flexibility allow. When you are able to lift your feet from the floor, be sure to lift slowly. Use your lower back to help control the ascent of your legs, and make sure to keep your chest open and stomach tight. This will keep your back aligned properly.

When the angle of your arms to your torso matches the angle of your thighs to your torso perfectly, you are approaching the top of the movement. At this point, exert your shoulders even more to complete the straight vertical straddle handstand position. Top this off by cleanly bringing your legs together from the straddle position.

If everything is falling into place but you are having trouble bringing your legs together from a straddle handstand to full handstand position, you have options to help seal the gap. You can perform negatives of this movement away from the wall, or possibly practice straddle handstands.

Keep in mind that even a five to ten degree bend in your elbows will make the movement about ten to thirty percent easier—and you will not see that strength gain as quickly. Resist the urge to bend your elbows.

STRADDLE OR PIKE STAND, PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 7



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas begin elevated. They will stay elevated for the entirety of this movement. All of the motion will come from your hips.

Technique: Begin with your hands on the ground and lean forward keeping your shoulder angle open. As your weight shifts to your hands, lift your hips over your head. Once you begin to feel that your feet are barely supporting your weight, slowly rotate your hips to a straddle handstand position. Then, bring your legs together and you will reach a handstand position.

When performing the *straddle or pike stand, press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *Str./Pike Std. Press*), lowering the level of your feet will make the movement significantly more challenging. More often than not, your hips will not be directly stacked over your shoulders when executing this skill. Let's break this skill down into two phases:

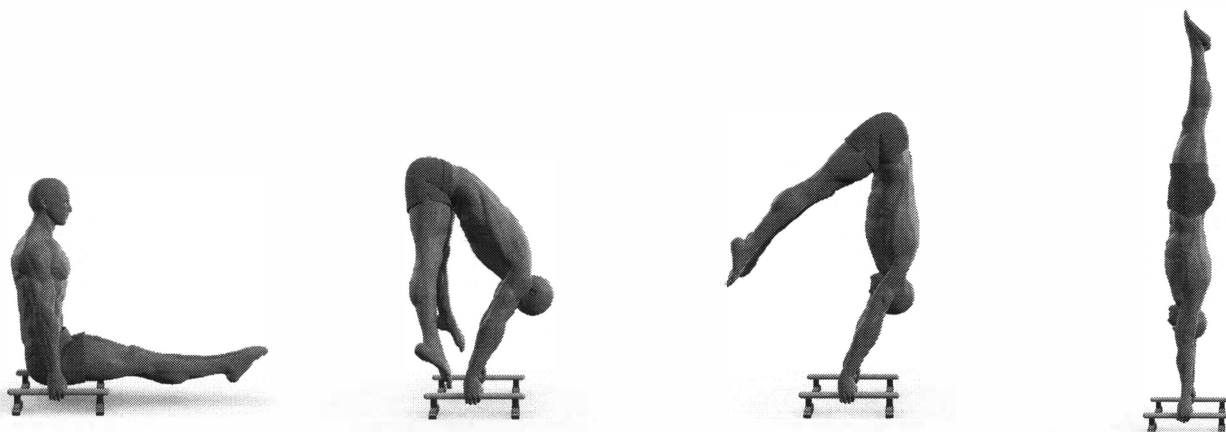
- For the first phase, forward lean onto your shoulders. After your weight is fully on your shoulders you must not allow the angle to close; if it does, the skill becomes significantly harder due to the extra forward lean or planching. Next, your torso and hips must rotate up while you keep your legs down, so that they are as directly over your shoulders as possible. This is called compression (a form of active flexibility) and it will keep your center of mass centered over your hands.
- For the second phase, raise your legs all the way up, through your hips, while pressing your shoulders back into place underneath your torso. Careful control of your core and hips will ensure proper form and balance.

You must be careful to get these distinct phases correct, as most beginners typically blend them together. If you lift your legs too soon (i.e. before your hips are above your shoulders), your shoulders will lean too far forward and you will fall on your face. Similarly, the control through your shoulders and core must remain constant; wobbling can also cause forward lean.

The pike variation is a bit harder because it requires extra forward lean at your shoulders, as your center of gravity is further away from your upper body. After you obtain the straddle straight-arm press to handstand, upgrading to the pike is a good way to progress the intensity.

Remember, even a “small” bend in your elbows (five to ten degrees!) will make the movement about ten to thirty percent easier. In order to gain the maximum from this movement, you should resist the urge to bend your elbows.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

L-SIT / STRADDLE-L, STRADDLE PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 8

Scapular Positioning: Begin in an L-sit position, with your scapulas depressed. As your hips begin to move overhead, your scapulas will protract and elevate. When your hips end up moving over your shoulders vertically, your scapulas will be fully elevated from there to the ending handstand position.

Technique: Begin in an L-sit position, with your arms straight. Allow your legs to drop and your shoulders to move slightly forward while lifting your hips in back. Keep your arms straight and contract your shoulders to prevent yourself from falling forward. Start to straddle as soon as your toes pass the bars. As your hips arrive to vertical above your shoulders, start to bring your legs up toward a straddle handstand position. Finally, bring your legs together to end in the handstand position.

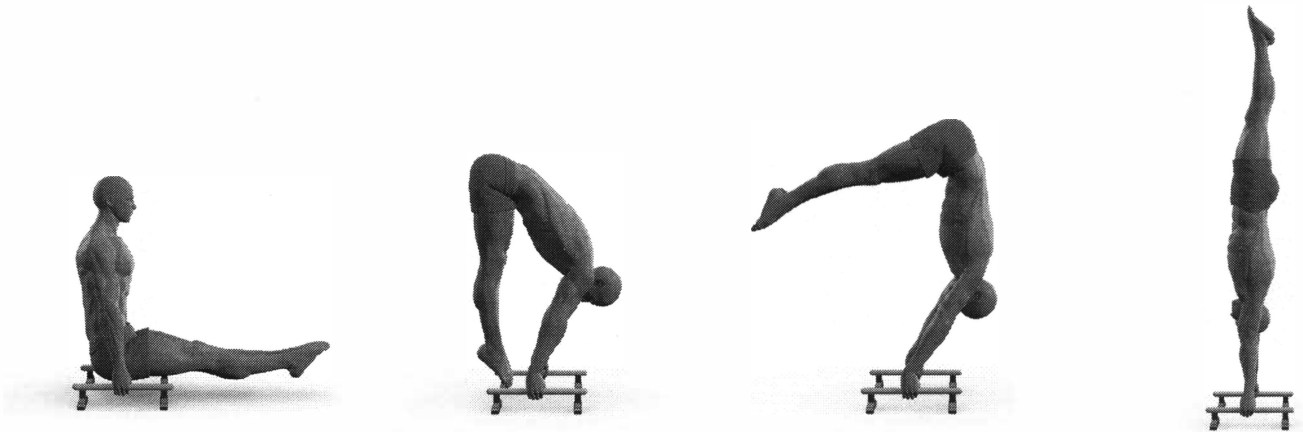
Since you are starting from a lower position with the *L-sit / straddle-L, straddle press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *L-Sit / Str-L Str. Press*), your range of motion will be increased, placing a greater demand on your shoulders. This forces you to apply much more strength, making you stronger. In this technique, compression is the key. You will need to maintain compression in order to keep your shoulders from planching too far forward. This must be achieved as soon as your hips begin to ascend. Essentially, once your hips start moving backward, you will squeeze your abdominals and immediately bring them as close to your face as possible.

As your proficiency increases, begin with a straddle L-sit. Doing this position from the start will make the movement more difficult in two ways: it nullifies most of the momentum you can build from swinging your legs backward from the L-sit position, and it also warrants a greater need for active flexibility and compression.

All of the L or straddle-L press variations have three components:

1. Raise your hips from a lower level, over your shoulders.
2. Bring your legs up to a straddle position overhead.
3. Finish in a handstand by opening your shoulders, closing your hips, and bringing your legs together.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

L-SIT / STRADDLE-L PIKE PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 9

Scapular Positioning: Begin in an L-sit position, with your scapulas depressed. As your hips begin to move overhead, your scapulas will protract and elevate. When your hips end up over your shoulders vertically, your scapulas will be fully elevated from there to the ending handstand position.

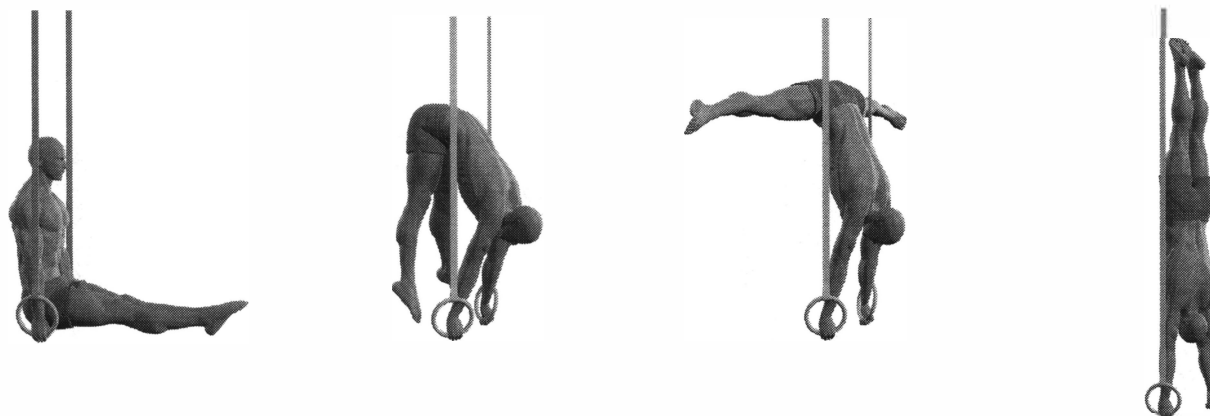
Technique: Begin in an L-sit position, with your arms straight. Allow your legs to drop and your shoulders to move slightly forward while your hips lift in back. Keep your arms straight and contract your shoulders to prevent yourself from falling forward. Since the straddle allows more compression with the pike, you will need to lean forward more with your shoulders as your hips rise. As your hips arrive to vertical above your shoulders, start to bring both of your legs up by opening up your hips. Finally, end in a handstand position.

The *L-sit / straddle-L pike press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *L-Sit / Str-L Pike Press*) is an extension of the previous presses. Because this movement involves keeping your legs together and straight, it requires more forward lean to execute. This requires more strength. To execute this movement, begin from the L-sit position and push your hips directly overhead before bringing your legs up to a handstand.

Alternatively, this can be performed from the straddle-L position. Once the legs clear the arms they need to come together to hit the pike position before the rest of the press can be finished. Technique is exactly the same as the other press techniques. Each of the phases should be separated as much as possible to prevent excessive planching and to allow active compression to develop further.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS STRAIGHT-ARM, L-SIT, STRADDLE PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Begin in an L-sit position, with your scapulas depressed. As your hips begin to move overhead, your scapulas will protract and elevate. When your hips arrive over your shoulders vertically, your scapulas remain fully elevated from there to the ending handstand position.

Technique: Begin in an L-sit position, with your arms straight on the rings. The rings can be either parallel or turned out. Allow your legs to drop and your shoulders to move slightly forward while lifting your hips in back. Keep your arms straight and contract your shoulders to keep from falling forward. Since the straddle allows more compression than the pike, you will need to lean forward more with your shoulders as your hips rise. As your hips come to vertical above your shoulders, start to bring both of your legs up by opening up your hips. Finally, end in a handstand position. Keep the rings in the starting position the entire time (either parallel or turned out).

Executing a *rings straight-arm, L-sit, straddle press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *RSA L-Sit Str. Press*) requires an enormous amount of strength and balance. It helps to have previously worked numerous variations of rings bent-arm press to handstands and rings handstands.

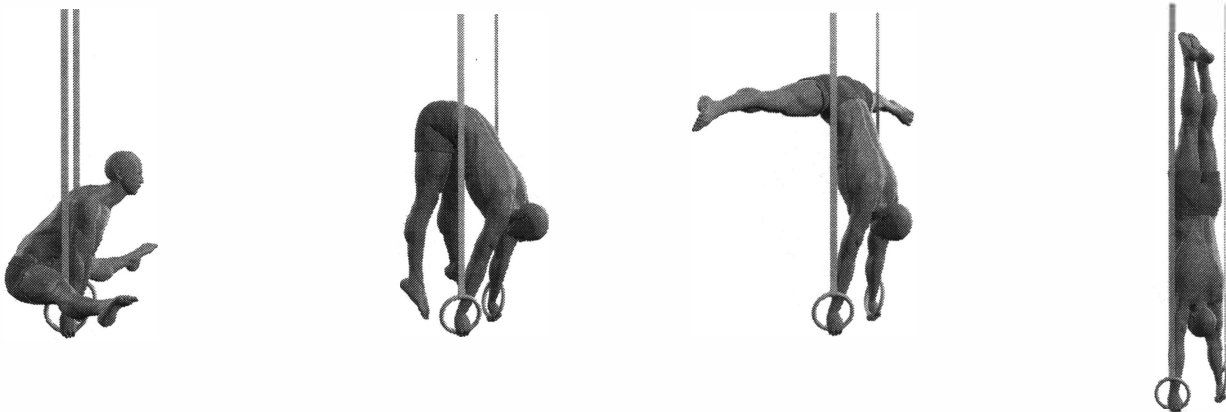
The technique for this skill centers on controlling the movement by turning the rings out. The necessity of locking your arms straight on the rings makes this skill very difficult due to the inherent instability with rings movements. Sufficient strength and control, coupled with turning out the rings should provide the adequate stability to perform this movement.

As soon as you turn out the rings, you must get your hips directly overhead. This will be the hardest part of the movement, as the instability of the rings makes it tricky. The instability will cause you to naturally lean forward and planche the movement, even though this ultimately makes it more difficult. Resist this urge by forcing your hips up while keeping your abdominals tight.

The bulk of the difficulty is in the first phase, where you must get your hips overhead. The second phase is relatively easy by comparison, as it entails simply bringing your legs up and together. Overcompensation is common; avoid it if at all possible, as it will cause you to fall forward. Since the difficulty level of this movement is so great, you can use a bit of momentum from the L-sit. This will be eliminated in the next progression.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS STRAIGHT-ARM, STRADDLE-L, STRADDLE PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 11



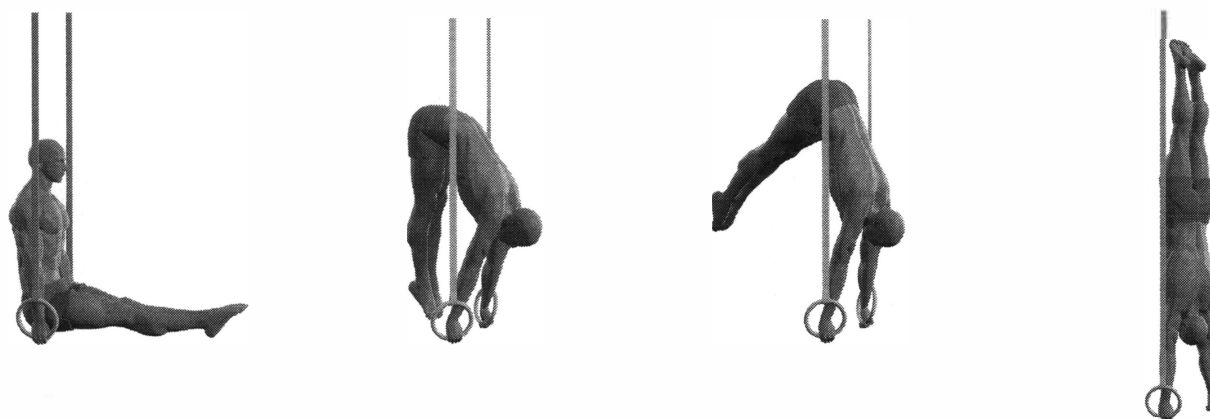
Scapular Positioning: Begin in a straddle L-sit position on the rings, with your scapulas depressed and slightly protracted. As your hips move overhead, your scapulas will protract and elevate. When your hips arrive over your shoulders vertically, your scapulas will be fully elevated. They remain fully elevated through the ending handstand position.

Technique: Begin in a straddle L-sit position on the rings with straight arms. The rings can be parallel or turned out. Allow your legs to drop and your shoulders to move slightly forward while lifting your hips in back. Keep your arms straight and contract your shoulders to keep from falling forward. Since the straddle allows more compression than the pike, you will need to lean forward more with your shoulders as your hips rise. As your hips become vertical above your shoulders, start to bring your legs up by opening up your hips. Finally, end in a handstand position. Keep the rings in the starting position the entire time (either parallel or turned out).

Momentum that can be generated from the previous skill is all but eliminated when performing the *rings straight-arm, straddle-L, straddle press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated as *R SA Str-L Str. Press*). One must have a tremendous amount of pressing strength in order to perform this movement correctly. The technique is exactly the same as the previous skill except you straddle from the start. Since the rings are already turned out you do not have to worry about that. Simply lean forward slightly and focus on pushing your hips up and overhead. From there, bring your legs together.

This movement performed cleanly, without momentum, is nearly as difficult as a full planche on parallel bars or the floor. When you have reached this level, your pressing strength is extremely advanced.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

RINGS STRAIGHT-ARM, PIKE PRESS TO HANDSTAND – LEVEL 12

Scapular Positioning: Begin in an L-sit position on the rings, with your scapulas depressed. As your hips begin to move overhead, your scapulas will protract and elevate. When your hips arrive over your shoulders vertically, your scapulas will be fully elevated. They should remain that way through the ending handstand position.

Technique: Begin in a straddle L-sit position on the rings with straight arms. The rings can be parallel or turned out. Allow your legs to drop and your shoulders to move slightly forward while lifting your hips in back. Keep your arms straight and contract your shoulders to keep from falling forward. As your hips become vertical above your shoulders, start to bring both of your legs up by opening up your hips. Finally, end in a handstand position. Keep the rings in the starting position the entire time (either parallel or turned out).

The *rings straight-arm, pike press to handstand* (which can be abbreviated *R SA Pike Press*) is as far as this book goes with straight-arm presses. While it is not as difficult as some of the variations of the planche on rings, when executed correctly it is almost or as difficult as a full planche on parallel bars or the floor. The technique is exactly the same, except you perform this movement from the pike position. The most difficult part is keeping your arms locked straight during the movement.

You must lean forward when performing this skill, as the pike position displaces your center of mass backward. There is a tendency to bend your arms to compensate because it requires less strength. However, you must not allow this to happen. Instead, keep your elbows locked and let your shoulder take the brunt of the force. This will strengthen your shoulders for many of the higher-skilled rings strength moves like the full planche, inverted cross, and maltese.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.